

AP ART HISTORY · THE UNIVERSAL STUDY GUIDE

Targeting a 3, 4, or 5 — every concept tagged for your tier

Tier badges: [3] foundational · [4] adds for 4+ · [5] adds for 5

Targeting a 4 → study [3] AND [4] items. Targeting a 5 → study all three tiers.

PAGE 1 | MATH OF 3/4/5 · 10 CONTENT AREAS · 250 REQUIRED WORKS

About this exam. AP Art History is built around **250 required works** spanning ~30,000 years (Paleolithic to contemporary) and 10 content areas (Global Prehistory through Contemporary). The exam tests **visual analysis + cultural context + comparison + attribution** — and rewards students who can write specific, evidence-based responses about works they've never seen by attributing them to the right region/period.

THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET

Target	MCQ (80q, 50%)	FRQ (6q, 50%)	Approx %	Tier
3 (PASS)	~38 / 80 (~48%)	~18-22/40 raw	~46-52%	[3]
4	~50 / 80 (~63%)	~26-30/40 raw	~60-66%	[3] + [4]
5	~62 / 80 (~78%)	~34-38/40 raw	~75-82%	All

Time: 60 min for 80 MCQ (~45 sec each — FAST), 120 min for 6 FRQs. **2 long FRQs (8 pts each) + 4 short FRQs (6 pts each).**

THE 10 CONTENT AREAS — by exam weight

#	Content Area	Weight	Era / focus
1	Global Prehistory	4%	30,000-500 BCE — cave paintings, megaliths, fertility figures
2	Ancient Mediterranean	15%	3500 BCE-300 CE — Egypt, Greece, Rome, Etruscans
3	Early Europe & Colonial Americas	21%	200-1750 CE — Byzantine, Islamic, Romanesque, Gothic, Renaissance, Baroque
4	Later Europe & Americas	21%	1750-1980 — Neoclassical, Romantic, Realist, Impressionism, Modernism
5	Indigenous Americas	6%	1000 BCE-1980 — Olmec, Maya, Aztec, Inca, Pueblo, Northwest Coast
6	Africa	6%	1100-1980 — Benin, Yoruba, Kongo, Lukasa, Olowe of Ise
7	West & Central Asia	4%	500 BCE-1980 — Persian, Buddhist Gandhara, Mughal, Suleymaniye
8	South, East & Southeast Asia	8%	300 BCE-1980 — Chinese, Japanese, Indian, Cambodian
9	Pacific	4%	700-1980 — Polynesian, Melanesian, Australian Indigenous
10	Global Contemporary	11%	1980-present — across cultures + media

KEY INSIGHT [3] Content areas 3 + 4 = 42% of the exam. Master European/colonial Americas (Byzantine through Modernism) — that's nearly half the points right there. Don't neglect smaller areas, but prioritize.

EXAM STRUCTURE — 6 FRQs

LONG FRQ #1 (8 pts) — "COMPARISON":

Given: 1 image of a required work + describe an unseen work.

Compare: visual elements + content + context.

LONG FRQ #2 (8 pts) — "VISUAL/CONTEXTUAL ANALYSIS":

Given: 1 image of an unseen work.

Analyze visual + interpret meaning + place in cultural context.

SHORT FRQs #3-6 (6 pts each):

#3 — Continuity & Change Over Time (one tradition through time)

#4 — Visual & Contextual Analysis (single required work, deep)

#5 — Attribution (image of unattributed work — use VISUAL EVIDENCE to argue when/where it's from + WHY)

#6 — Theory & Interpretation (apply a critical framework)

PAGE 2 | VISUAL ANALYSIS TOOLKIT — THE FOUNDATION

Every FRQ requires visual analysis. Memorize this vocabulary — these are the CONCRETE observations graders reward. "This work is beautiful" = 0 points. "The artist uses linear perspective with a single vanishing point at the figure of Christ" = points for visual analysis.

Formal Elements [3]/[4]

Element	Vocabulary + observations to make
Line	Contour, gesture, hatching/cross-hatching; horizontal (calm), vertical (formal/spiritual), diagonal (action)
Shape / Form	Geometric vs organic; 2-D shapes vs 3-D forms (mass, volume)
Color	Hue, value, saturation, complementary, analogous; symbolic uses (gold = divine, red = passion/blood)
Texture	Actual (sculpted) vs implied (painted); rough/smooth/shiny
Space	Linear perspective , atmospheric (color/clarity fades), overlapping, foreshortening
Composition	Symmetry/asymmetry, balance, focal point, hierarchical scale (bigger = more important), pyramidal/triangular composition
Light	Naturalistic, dramatic (chiaroscuro = strong dark/light), tenebrism (Caravaggio's dark backgrounds)
Materials/Medium	Fresco, oil, tempera, acrylic, bronze, marble, terracotta, stained glass, mosaic, woodblock

Subject Matter Vocabulary [3]/[4]

GENRES:

Portrait – depiction of specific person
 Landscape – natural scenery dominant
 History painting – narrative event (high genre per academic hierarchy)
 Genre scene – everyday life
 Still life – inanimate objects
 Religious – Christian, Buddhist, Islamic, etc.
 Allegory – symbolic representation of an idea

ARCHITECTURE TERMS:

Post-and-lintel, arch, vault (barrel/groin/rib), dome
 Buttress (flying buttress = Gothic), pendentive, pilaster
 Nave, apse, transept (church plan terms)

Iconography [4]/[5]

[4]/[5] **Iconography = symbols + their meanings in art.** Memorize the most common:

- **Mary blue robe [4]** = purity, divinity. Often holding white lily (purity).
- **Christ on cross [4]**: INRI (King of the Jews), wounds in hands/feet/side, crown of thorns.
- **Halo [4]** = divinity. Cruciform halo for Christ, golden disc for saints.
- **Skull / hourglass [5]** = vanitas (mortality, transience of life).
- **Lotus flower [4]** = Buddhist purity, enlightenment.
- **Lion [4]** = strength, courage, royalty (or St. Mark in Christian art).

KEY INSIGHT [5] On Visual Analysis FRQs, structure your answer as: (1) describe what you see, (2) explain its function or meaning, (3) connect to context. Don't separate description from interpretation — weave them. "The figure's gold halo and elongated proportions [VISUAL] reflect Byzantine conventions emphasizing spiritual over physical reality [INTERPRETATION], typical of post-iconoclasm icon production [CONTEXT]."

PAGE 3 | ANCIENT MEDITERRANEAN — EGYPT · GREECE · ROME

Egypt (~3000-30 BCE) [3]/[4]

- **Conventions [3]/[4]:** composite/twisted view (head profile, eye frontal, torso frontal, legs profile); hierarchical scale; rigidity; emphasis on order + afterlife.
- **Key works [3]/[4]:** **Great Pyramids of Giza** (Khufu, Khafre, Menkaure, c. 2550 BCE); **King Menkaure & Queen** (sculpture, ~2490 BCE); **Akhenaton + Nefertiti / Akhenaton with daughters** (Amarna period, ~1350 BCE — naturalistic shift).
- **Amarna [4]/[5]** = brief naturalistic break under Akhenaten (monotheistic reform). Reverted after his death.

Greece (~800-30 BCE) [3]/[4]**ARCHAIC (~700-480 BCE):**

Kouros ("Anavysos" Kouros): rigid, smile, frontal, Egyptian-influenced

CLASSICAL (~480-323 BCE):

Contrapposto pose (weight shift), idealization, balance

Doryphoros (Polykleitos) — canon of proportions

Parthenon (Athens, 447-432 BCE): Doric, golden ratio,

Phidias's sculptural program

HELLENISTIC (~323-30 BCE):

Drama + emotion + virtuosic carving

Nike of Samothrace (Winged Victory)

Laocoön and His Sons

Old market woman (genre realism, not idealization)

Rome (~700 BCE-476 CE) [3]/[4]

- **Architecture [3]/[4]:** arch, dome, concrete enabled scale. **Pantheon** (oculus dome). **Colosseum** (stacked orders). **Augustus of Prima Porta**.
- **Roman portraiture [4]:** VERISTIC (warts-and-all realism) under Republic; idealized propaganda under emperors (Augustus).
- **Conversion to Christianity [4]/[5]** (Constantine, 312 CE) → basilicas (Old St. Peter's), Christian iconography emerges.

PAGE 4 | EARLY EUROPE: BYZANTINE · ROMANESQUE · GOTHIC · RENAISSANCE

Byzantine + Islamic [3]/[4]

- **Hagia Sophia [3]/[4]** (537 CE, Justinian) — massive dome on pendentives. Originally Byzantine cathedral, became mosque after 1453, now museum/mosque.
- **Mosaics + icons [3]/[4]**: gold backgrounds (divine light), elongated figures, frontality, hieratic scale. **Theotokos (Virgin) and Child between Saints**.
- **Iconoclasm controversy [5]** = whether religious images allowed (~726-843 CE).
- **Islamic art [3]/[4]**: aniconism (no figural in religious contexts), arabesque, calligraphy, geometric. **Great Mosque of Córdoba, Dome of the Rock, Suleymaniye Mosque (Sinan)**.

Romanesque + Gothic [3]/[4]

Style	Features
Romanesque (~1000-1150)	Thick walls, small windows, rounded arches, barrel vaults, stone vaulted ceilings. Sainte-Foy at Conques, Bayeux Tapestry .
Gothic (~1150-1500)	Pointed arches, ribbed vaults, flying buttresses (allowed thinner walls + LARGER windows = stained glass). Vertical emphasis, light = divine. Chartres Cathedral, Notre-Dame de Paris, Saint-Chapelle .

Italian Renaissance (~1400-1600) [3]/[4]/[5]

- **Linear perspective [3]/[4]** (Brunelleschi/Alberti) — vanishing point, mathematical illusion of depth.
- **Early Renaissance [4]**: Donatello (David — first nude since antiquity), Masaccio (Tribute Money — perspective + chiaroscuro), Brunelleschi (Florence Cathedral dome).
- **High Renaissance [3]/[4]**: Leonardo (Mona Lisa, Last Supper), Michelangelo (Sistine Ceiling, David, Pietà), Raphael (School of Athens).
- **Northern Renaissance [4]/[5]**: Jan van Eyck's Arnolfini Portrait (oil paint, naturalism, symbolism), Dürer (printmaking, self-portraits).
- **Venetian Renaissance [5]**: Titian (color over line; Venus of Urbino).

Mannerism + Baroque [3]/[4]/[5]

- **Mannerism (~1520-1600) [4]/[5]** = anti-classical reaction. Elongated figures, complex composition, anxiety. Pontormo's Entombment, Parmigianino's Madonna of the Long Neck.
- **Baroque (1600-1750) [3]/[4]**: drama, emotion, theatricality, motion. Counter-Reformation tool.
- **Caravaggio [4]/[5]**: tenebrism (extreme dark/light), gritty realism. **Calling of St. Matthew, Conversion of Saul**.
- **Bernini [4]**: sculptural drama. **Ecstasy of St. Teresa, David**.
- **Dutch Golden Age [4]/[5]**: middle-class genre painting. Vermeer (light, domestic interiors), Rembrandt (portraits, self-portraits, biblical).

PAGE 5 | LATER EUROPE & AMERICAS — NEOCLASSICAL THROUGH MODERNISM

Neoclassicism (~1750-1820) [3]/[4]

- **Neoclassicism [3]** = revival of classical (Greek/Roman) forms. Order, restraint, civic virtue. Tied to Enlightenment + American/French Revolutions.
- **Jacques-Louis David [3]/[4]: Oath of the Horatii** (Roman virtue, masculine sacrifice). **Death of Marat** (revolutionary martyr).
- **Architecture [4]:** Monticello (Jefferson), US Capitol — modeled on classical temples + domes.

Romanticism (~1800-1850) [3]/[4]

- **Romanticism [3]** = emotion, individualism, nature's sublime power. REACTION against Enlightenment rationalism.
- **Goya [4]: Third of May 1808** (Napoleonic execution; horror of war). **Saturn Devouring His Son** (dark nightmares).
- **Delacroix [4]: Liberty Leading the People** (1830 revolution, allegory).
- **Friedrich [4]/[5]: Wanderer Above the Sea of Fog** (sublime landscape, individual confronting infinity).

Realism (~1840-1880) [3]/[4]

- **Realism [3]/[4]** = depict ordinary life truthfully. NO idealization. Rural laborers, urban poor.
- **Courbet [4]: Stone Breakers** (1849) — manual laborers, large-scale (which was reserved for history painting). **Burial at Ornans**.
- **Manet [4]/[5]: Olympia** (modern courtesan replacing classical Venus — scandalous). Bridges Realism + Impressionism.

Impressionism + Post-Impressionism [3]/[4]/[5]

- **Impressionism (~1870s-1890s) [3]/[4]:** capture fleeting LIGHT + atmosphere. Plein air. Visible brushstrokes. Modern subjects (cafés, leisure, suburbs). **Monet, Renoir, Degas, Berthe Morisot**.
- **Post-Impressionism (~1880s-1900s) [4]/[5]:** rejected pure observation; emphasized structure (Cézanne), emotion (Van Gogh), symbolism (Gauguin), pointillism (Seurat).

Modernism — early 20th century [3]/[4]/[5]

Movement	Description + key works
Fauvism	Pure intense color (Matisse — <i>The Joy of Life</i>)
Cubism [3]/[4]	Picasso & Braque. Fractured planes, multiple viewpoints. Picasso's <i>Les Femmes d'Alger (O.J.)</i> (1911).
German Expressionism	Anxiety, distortion (Kirchner, Kollwitz)
Futurism	Speed, machine, motion (Boccioni's <i>Unique Forms of Continuity in Space</i>)
Dada	Anti-art, anti-bourgeois (Duchamp's <i>Fountain</i> — readymade, urinal)
Surrealism	Dreams, unconscious (Dalí, Magritte, Frida Kahlo's psychological self-portraits)
Bauhaus	Function + form unified (architecture + design)
Mexican Muralism	Public art + politics (Diego Rivera, José Clemente Orozco)
Abstract Expressionism	Post-WWII NY. Pollock (drip), Rothko (color fields), Lee Krasner.
Pop Art	Mass culture (Warhol's <i>Marilyn</i> , Lichtenstein's comics)

KEY INSIGHT [5] Use the "-isms" pattern. When discussing 19th-20th century art, frame movements as REACTIONS: Romanticism reacts to Neoclassical rationalism; Realism reacts to Romantic idealism; Impressionism reacts to academic finish; Cubism reacts to one-point perspective; Dada reacts to WWI horror. Sophistication via this evolutionary chain.

PAGE 6 | INDIGENOUS AMERICAS · AFRICA · ASIA · PACIFIC

Indigenous Americas (~1000 BCE-1980) [3]/[4]

- **Mesoamerica [3]/[4]:** Olmec colossal heads, Maya (Yaxchilán lintels, blood-letting rituals), Aztec (Templo Mayor, **Coatlicue** — Earth goddess), **Inca Machu Picchu**, ashlar masonry.
- **North America [4]:** Mississippian cultures (Cahokia mounds), **Anasazi/Pueblo** (kivas at Mesa Verde), Northwest Coast (totem poles, transformation masks), Plains hide paintings.
- **Post-contact [5]:** indigenous artists adapt European tools but retain content (e.g., 18th-century Pueblo pottery).

Africa (~1100-1980) [3]/[4]

- **Great Zimbabwe [4]** (1100-1450) — stone-walled royal complex.
- **Benin (Nigeria) [3]/[4]:** cast bronze plaques + heads. **Wall plaque from Oba's palace**, **Ife head** (ancient royal portraits — naturalistic).
- **Yoruba [4]:** **Olowe of Ise** — 20th-c. carver, palace doors. Ifa divination.
- **Kongo [4]:** **Nkisi nkondi** = power figure, nails driven in to activate spirits.
- **Lukasa memory board (Luba) [4]/[5]** = mnemonic device for oral history.

West & Central Asia [4]/[5]

- **Persian [4]:** Persepolis (Darius's palace), **Ardabil Carpet** (Safavid).
- **Buddhist Gandhara [4]/[5]:** synthesizes Greek + Indian (1st-5th c. CE).
- **Mughal India [4]:** Taj Mahal (Shah Jahan, 1632-53), Persian-Indian-Islamic synthesis.
- **Ottoman [4]:** Sinan's **Suleymaniye Mosque** (1558) — domed central plan.

South / East / SE Asia [3]/[4]

- **India [3]/[4]:** **Great Stupa at Sanchi** (Buddhist), Hindu temples (Khajuraho, Tanjore), Mughal Taj Mahal.
- **China [3]/[4]:** Terracotta Army of Qin Shihuang (~210 BCE), Tang/Song landscapes (**Travelers among Mountains and Streams** by Fan Kuan), **Forbidden City**.
- **Japan [3]/[4]:** **Todaiji** (Nara, Buddhist), Heian-era (Tale of Genji handscrolls), **Edo woodblock prints** (Hokusai's *Great Wave*, Hiroshige). Zen aesthetics (Ryoanji garden).
- **Cambodia [4]:** Angkor Wat (12th c.) — Hindu/Buddhist.

Pacific (~700-1980) [4]/[5]

- **Polynesia [4]:** **Moai of Easter Island**, Hawaiian feather cloaks, Maori meeting houses.
- **Melanesia [4]:** malagan ceremonial figures, latmul men's house carvings.
- **Aboriginal Australian [4]/[5]:** Dreaming paintings (dot painting, Papunya Tula movement).

PAGE 7 | GLOBAL CONTEMPORARY · CRITICAL FRAMEWORKS

Contemporary (1980-present) [3]/[4]/[5]

Contemporary art = ~11% of exam. Diverse media + global perspectives + identity politics.

KEY ARTISTS / WORKS:

Kara Walker – silhouette installations (race, slavery, gender)
 Kiki Smith – body, mortality (Lying with the Wolf)
 Yinka Shonibare – "Dutch wax" cloth + Western dress (colonialism, hybridity)
 Ai Weiwei – Chinese activist (Sunflower Seeds, dropping Han urn)
 Marina Abramović – performance, endurance
 Doris Salcedo – installation about violence (Shibboleth, Colombian)
 Jenny Holzer – text projections (truisms)
 Cindy Sherman – staged self-portraits (gender, identity)
 Frank Gehry – Guggenheim Bilbao (deconstructivist architecture)
 Maya Lin – Vietnam Veterans Memorial (minimal, healing)
 Andy Goldsworthy – environmental, ephemeral
 Banksy – street art, political

Critical Frameworks for FRQ #6 [4]/[5]

Framework	Lens / questions to ask
Patronage [3]/[4]	Who paid for it? What did they want? (Church, state, wealthy patron, modern museum?)
Function [3]/[4]	Religious worship? Political propaganda? Funerary? Decorative? Educational?
Gender [4]/[5]	Who made it? Who's depicted? How are women represented? (Berger's <i>Ways of Seeing</i>)
Race / Ethnicity [4]/[5]	Who's centered, who's marginalized? Whose perspective?
Colonialism / Post-colonial [4]/[5]	Did colonizer/colonized make it? Power dynamics? Cultural appropriation?
Reception [4]/[5]	How was it received in its time? How is it received now? Has meaning changed?
Material / Process [4]	How was it made? What does material choice signify?
Iconography [4]	What symbols + meanings? Conventional or innovative?

KEY INSIGHT [5] FRQ #6 (Theory) is the hardest for most students. Pre-load 2-3 critical frameworks you understand well. When prompt asks "using a specific theoretical perspective..." — pick patronage, gender, OR colonialism + apply rigorously.

PAGE 8 | ATTRIBUTION FRQ · ANSWER STRUCTURE**FRQ #5 — Attribution to a Culture/Period [4]/[5]**

You're given an unidentified work. Use **VISUAL EVIDENCE** to argue its likely origin. This is the trickiest FRQ — you must reason from what you SEE to a defensible attribution.

ANSWER STRUCTURE:

1. State your attribution clearly (e.g., "This work is most likely Byzantine, likely from the 9th-11th century").
2. Provide TWO specific visual features supporting attribution.
3. Connect each feature to the period's conventions.
4. Acknowledge alternative attributions briefly + explain why yours is stronger.

EXAMPLE for an icon-style image:

"This work is likely Byzantine, mid-period (9th-12th c.). The gold background indicates divine light, characteristic of Byzantine icons reaffirmed after iconoclasm. The figures' frontal pose, elongated proportions, and stylized, non-naturalistic drapery further suggest Byzantine conventions emphasizing spiritual over physical reality. While early medieval Western European art shares some traits, the gold leaf and hieratic frontality more strongly suggest Byzantine workshop production."

FRQ Universal Answer Structure — D-A-C [3]/[4]/[5]

Every visual analysis answer should layer:

D – DESCRIBE: What you literally see (form, line, color, composition, scale).
 "The figure is centered against a gold background, holding a child..."

A – ANALYZE: What the visual choices DO for the viewer.
 "The frontal pose and direct gaze command the viewer's attention, creating intimacy between viewer + holy figures..."

C – CONNECT: Cultural/historical/functional context.
 "This frontality is typical of Byzantine icons designed for veneration in church spaces, where direct visual encounter with the holy was considered theologically important..."

Long FRQ — "Comparison" Structure [4]/[5]

Long FRQ #1 (Comparison): you must compare on:

1. Visual features (composition, materials, scale, color, etc.)
2. Subject/content (what's depicted + meaning)
3. Cultural/historical context (when/where/why made)

Best structure:

- Para 1: Identify both works (titles, periods, brief description)
- Para 2: Compare VISUAL features (specific!)
- Para 3: Compare SUBJECT + meaning
- Para 4: Compare CONTEXT – patronage, function, audience
- Para 5: Synthesize – what does the comparison illuminate?

KEY INSIGHT [5] FRQ-graders reward the SYNTHESIS at the end. Don't just list similarities + differences — argue what the comparison TEACHES us.

"This comparison reveals how the rise of secular patronage in Northern Europe shifted artistic emphasis from spiritual to mercantile values, a transition not yet present in Italy at the same time."

PAGE 9 | MCQ STRATEGY · COMMON MISTAKES · TIME MANAGEMENT**MCQ Time Strategy [3]/[4]**

60 min for 80 questions = 45 sec per question. FAST.

Question types:

Image-based (most): 4-5 images shown; identify, attribute, interpret
Text-based: vocabulary, context, function

STRATEGY:

1. Skip + flag any question taking >60 seconds – return at end.
2. For image attribution Qs: look at conventions you recognize
(gold background = Byzantine; flying buttress = Gothic; Cubist fragmentation; Egyptian composite view; etc.).
3. Eliminate clearly wrong answers FIRST.
4. Answer EVERY question (no penalty for wrong; ~25% from random guess).

Mistakes that cap your score at 3 [3]/[4]

- **Pure description without analysis or context.** "It's a painting of Mary holding baby Jesus." Earns 0 — every observation must do work.
- **Vague terms.** "It's beautiful / interesting / detailed." Replace with specific vocabulary (chiaroscuro, contrapposto, hierarchical scale, etc.).
- **Wrong period attribution** in long FRQ. Always at least IDENTIFY which culture/period before describing.
- **Skipping the comparison synthesis** in Long FRQ #1. Listing similarities/differences without arguing significance loses points.

Mistakes that cap your score at 4 [4]/[5]

- **No iconography reading.** Symbols (lily, halo, skull, lotus) carry meaning — read them when present.
- **Forgetting patronage / function** as part of context. Who paid for it + what was its purpose are baseline questions.
- **Generic context** ("during the Renaissance..."). Be specific — "during the early Italian Renaissance under Medici patronage, c. 1480..."
- **Treating Western works as default.** AP Art History rewards balanced cross-cultural treatment. Don't favor Europe.
- **Missing critical framework on FRQ #6.** Pre-load 2-3 frameworks (gender, colonialism, patronage).

Quick study technique [4]/[5]

FOR EACH OF THE 250 REQUIRED WORKS, know:

- Title + artist (if known)
- Date + culture/period
- Material + scale
- 2-3 key visual features
- Function + patronage
- 1 sentence about its significance

Use FLASHCARDS (image on front, info on back).

GROUP works by content area for comparison practice.

Pre-load TIMELINE landmarks: 30,000 BCE prehistory, 2500 BCE Egyptian pyramids, 480 BCE Greek classical, 30 BCE-300 CE Rome, 312 CE Christianity legalized, 537 CE Hagia Sophia, 800 CE Carolingian, 1150 Gothic, 1400 Renaissance, 1517 Reformation, 1600 Baroque, 1750 Neoclassical, 1830 Romantic, 1860 Realist, 1875 Impressionist, 1907 Cubist, 1945 AbEx, 1980+ Contemporary.

PAGE 10 | SCORE LADDER · TIER CHECKLISTS · THE ONE THING

THE SCORE LADDER

For a 3 (Pass)	For a 4	For a 5
MCQ: 38-44 / 80	MCQ: 50-56 / 80	MCQ: 62-68 / 80
Identify major periods + 1-2 representative works.	Know 100+ specific required works with dates + cultures.	Master most of 250 + cross-cultural connections.
Visual analysis: basic vocabulary (color, line, composition).	Visual analysis layered with context.	D-A-C structure with specific iconography + critical framework.
FRQ #5 attribution: name a culture, give 1 visual reason.	Attribution: name period precisely + 2-3 visual reasons.	Attribution + acknowledge alternatives + defend best fit.
Long FRQ comparison: list similarities + differences.	Compare visual + content + context.	Synthesis: argue what comparison REVEALS.

TIER-SPECIFIC TEST-DAY CHECKLISTS

For a 3 — focus only on these:

- ✓ MCQ: 38+ correct.
- ✓ Memorize 50-100 most-canonical works (Pyramids, Parthenon, Hagia Sophia, Mona Lisa, Sistine Ceiling, Olympia, Demoiselles, Great Wave).
- ✓ Use vocabulary words: contrapposto, chiaroscuro, perspective, fresco, tempera.
- ✓ Don't just describe — connect to function or context.
- ✓ Long FRQ: identify both works + give context.

For a 4 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 50+ correct.
- ✓ Know 100+ required works with dates + cultures.
- ✓ Use D-A-C structure on every FRQ paragraph.
- ✓ Attribution FRQ: 2-3 specific visual features tied to period conventions.
- ✓ Discuss patronage + function explicitly.
- ✓ Identify iconography (halo, lotus, skull, etc.).

For a 5 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 62+ correct.
- ✓ Master most of the 250 required works.
- ✓ Apply critical framework (gender, colonialism, patronage) on FRQ #6.
- ✓ Long FRQ comparison: SYNTHESIS at end ("this comparison reveals...").
- ✓ Acknowledge alternative attributions on Attribution FRQ.
- ✓ Cross-cultural connections (e.g., Buddhist Gandhara synthesizing Greek + Indian).
- ✓ Use "-isms reaction chain": each movement responds to the previous.

THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST [3][4][5]: VISUAL EVIDENCE → INTERPRETATION → CONTEXT. AP Art History rewards students who can MOVE from what they see ("the gold background, frontal pose, elongated proportions") to what those choices DO ("emphasize spiritual over physical reality") to what context produced them ("Byzantine post-iconoclasm icon production"). **Every observation must do work.** Pure description = 0. Pure interpretation without evidence = 0. The chain visual evidence → interpretation → context = full credit. Drill the D-A-C structure into every FRQ paragraph.

If you do nothing else: master the D-A-C structure, learn 100 most-canonical works precisely, and pre-load 2-3 critical frameworks for FRQ #6.

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